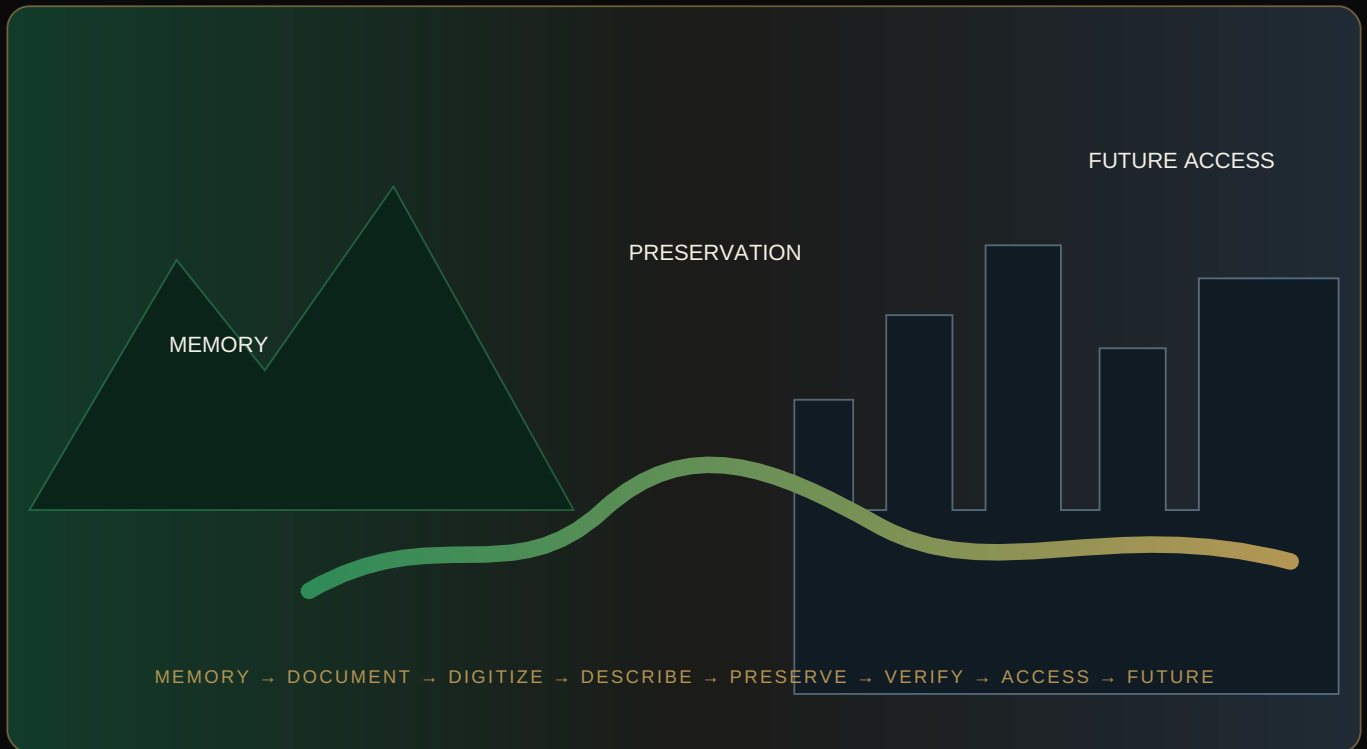


DIGITAL PRESERVATION OF HISTORY

“Preserve the evidence. Preserve the context. Preserve the memory.”



Digital Preservation: Connecting ancestral memory to future generations through evidence and context.

“History can disappear without anyone deciding to destroy it. A photograph fades. A notebook is lost. A recording becomes unreadable. A family story dies with the person who remembered it. A document remains in a box until nobody knows what it contains. And sometimes an entire generation remembers an event differently because the original evidence was never preserved.

Digital technology offers a powerful opportunity. A photograph can be scanned. A voice can be recorded. A manuscript can be photographed. A map can be digitized. An oral history can be indexed. A family archive can be copied across generations.

But pressing ‘scan’ is not the same as preserving history. Preservation requires context, provenance, metadata, redundancy, care and responsible access. For Orakzai history, digital preservation can become a bridge between memory and future generations.”

WHAT IS DIGITAL PRESERVATION?

Digital preservation is the managed process of maintaining digital objects and their meaning over time so they remain accessible, authentic and usable. It is critical to distinguish between **digitization** (the act of creating a digital copy) and **digital preservation** (the long-term stewardship of that copy). A digital file without metadata, backups, and a plan for format migration is at high risk of being lost.

HISTORICAL SOURCES: PRIMARY VS SECONDARY

Orakzai history exists across multiple formats, including family memory, oral histories, photographs, letters, land records, genealogies, manuscripts, and colonial documents. Digitization does not change a source's original status: a scanned colonial document remains a **primary source** from its period, while a modern article describing it is a **secondary source**. Sources have different evidentiary values and must be read critically.

DIGITIZATION VS PRESERVATION

Feature	Digitization	Digital Preservation
Goal	Create a digital representation	Maintain access and meaning over time
Process	Scanning / Recording	Active management / Redundancy
Metadata	Minimal or none	Comprehensive context and technical data
Sustainability	Short-term access	Long-term stewardship
Risk	High (Obsolescence / Loss)	Managed and mitigated

PHOTOGRAPH PRESERVATION WORKFLOW

Family photographs are valuable visual memories. Preserving them requires careful handling of the original, high-quality capture (e.g., TIFF format for masters), comprehensive metadata (who, what, when, where), and a robust backup strategy. We do

not automatically assume an unidentified person is a tribal leader without evidence; metadata should clearly state "unknown" when information is missing.

ORAL HISTORY AND ETHICS

Oral history records lived experience and spoken memory. Digital preservation involves recording original voices, transcribing them, and potentially translating them for broader access. **Informed consent** is the ethical foundation: participants must understand the purpose, storage, and future use of their recordings. Privacy must be respected, especially regarding sensitive family data or children's records.

AI AND CULTURAL AUTHENTICITY

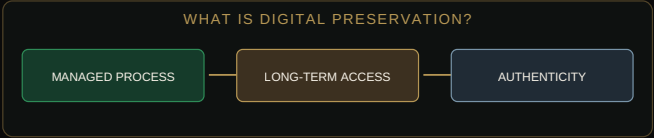
AI tools can assist in OCR, transcription, and image restoration, but they are not historical authorities. AI can hallucinate or misidentify people. A digitally restored image should always preserve the original file, and any generative changes must be clearly labeled. We do not present AI-generated reconstructions as original historical evidence.

PRESERVATION CLAIM MATRIX

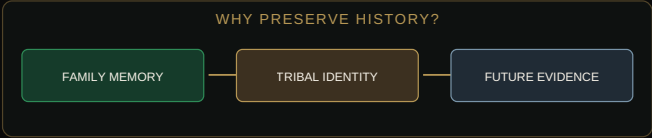
Claim	Source Type	Evidence	Source	Confidence
Digitization ≠ Preservation	International Standard	UNESCO/PERSIST Guidelines	UNESCO (2021)	High
3-2-1 Backup Rule	Technical Standard	Industry best practice	DPC (2025)	High
Oral History as Evidence	Methodology	CAP Project data	CAP (2023)	High
Metadata Necessity	Archival Standard	Dublin Core Initiative	IFLA (2021)	High

PROPOSED ORAKZAI DIGITAL ARCHIVE — CONCEPT

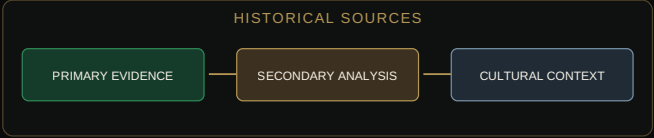
While no formal "Orakzai Digital Archive" currently exists, a proposed conceptual framework would include categories for History, Photographs, Oral Histories, Documents, Maps, Pashto, Music, Poetry, Family Archives, Migration, Community Records, and Research Sources. This community-led archive would prioritize provenance, context, and responsible access levels (Open, Limited, Restricted, Private).



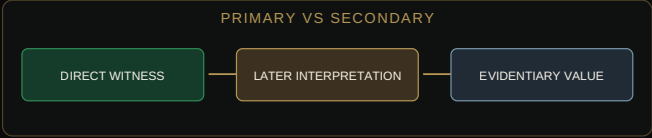
1. What is digital preservation? — preservation framework.



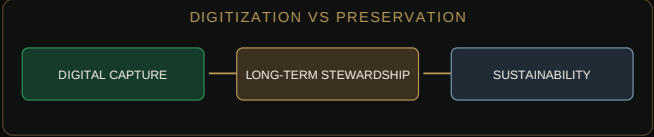
2. Why preserve history? — preservation framework.



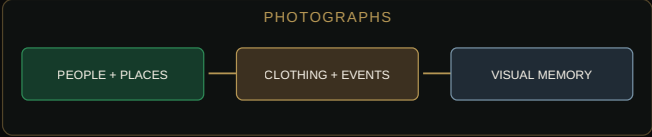
3. Historical sources — preservation framework.



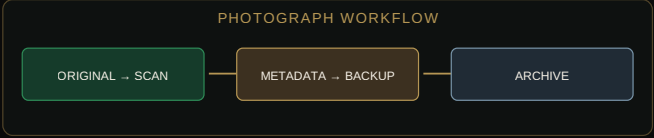
4. Primary vs secondary — preservation framework.



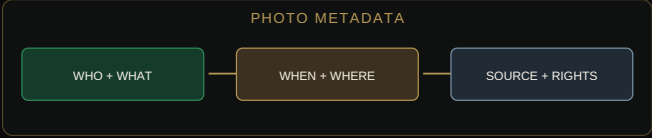
5. Digitization vs preservation — preservation framework.



6. Photographs — preservation framework.



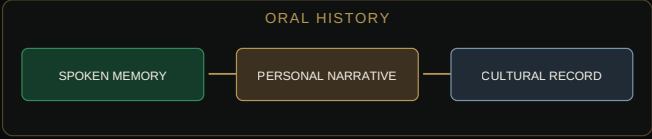
7. Photograph workflow — preservation framework.



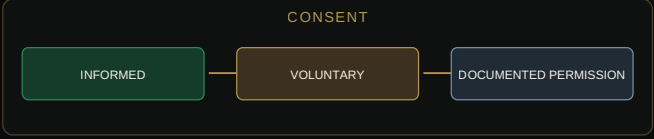
8. Photo metadata — preservation framework.



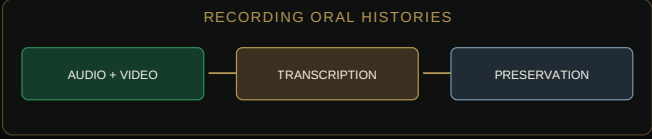
9. Family photographs — preservation framework.



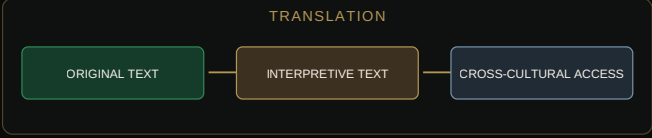
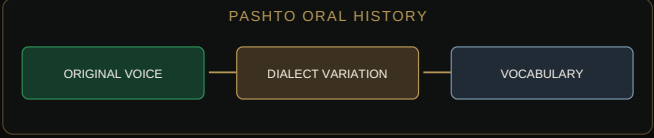
10. Oral history — preservation framework.



11. Consent — preservation framework.



12. Recording oral histories — preservation framework.



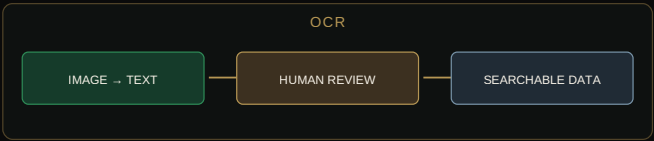
13. Pashto oral history — preservation framework.

14. Translation — preservation framework.



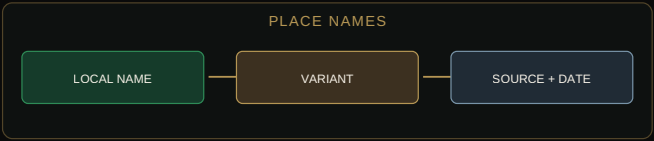
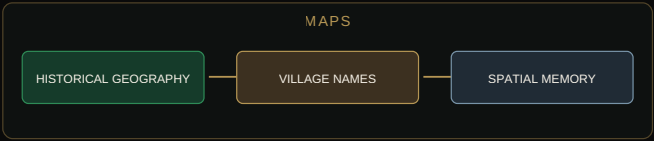
15. Manuscripts — preservation framework.

16. Document digitization — preservation framework.



17. OCR — preservation framework.

18. Manuscript preservation — preservation framework.



19. Maps — preservation framework.

20. Place names — preservation framework.



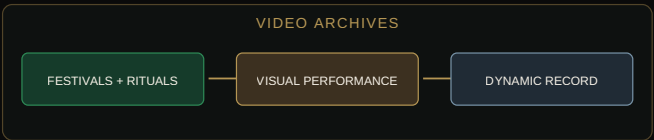
21. Genealogies — preservation framework.

22. Colonial records — preservation framework.



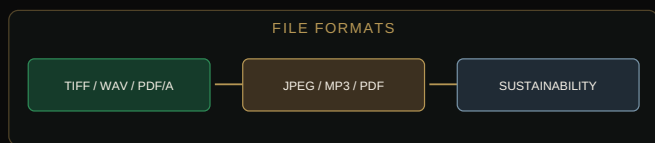
23. Multiple sources — preservation framework.

24. Newspapers — preservation framework.

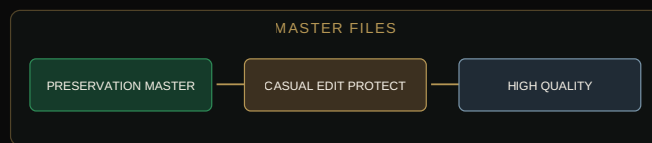


25. Audio archives — preservation framework.

26. Video archives — preservation framework.



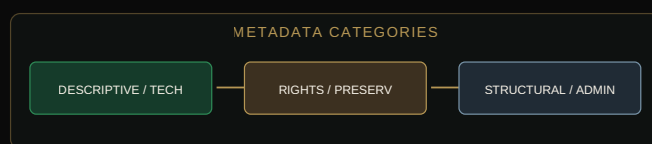
27. File formats — preservation framework.



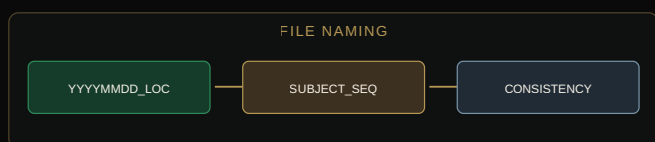
28. Master files — preservation framework.



29. Metadata — preservation framework.



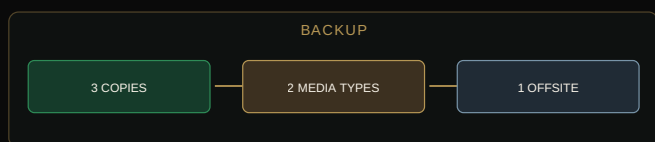
30. Metadata categories — preservation framework.



31. File naming — preservation framework.



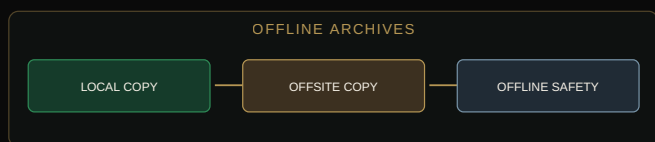
32. Folder structure — preservation framework.



33. Backup — preservation framework.



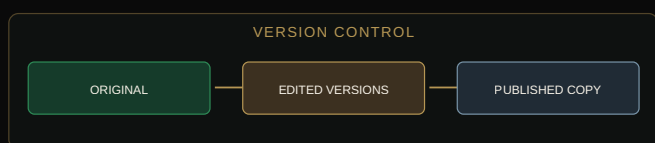
34. Cloud storage — preservation framework.



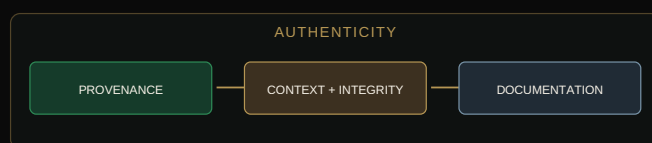
35. Offline archives — preservation framework.



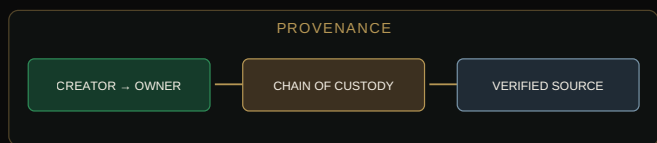
36. Checksums — preservation framework.



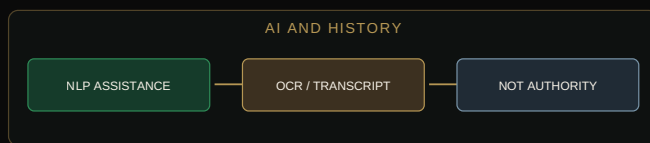
37. Version control — preservation framework.



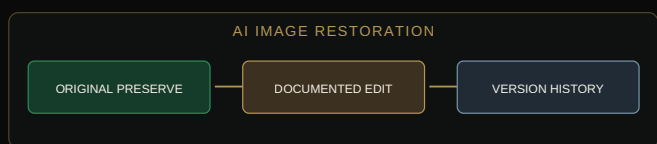
38. Authenticity — preservation framework.



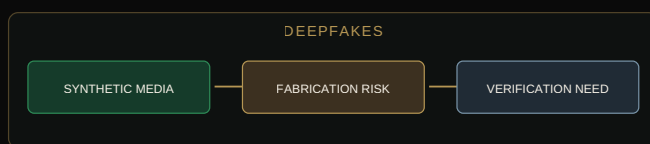
39. Provenance — preservation framework.



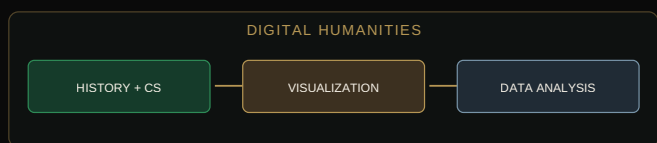
40. AI and history — preservation framework.



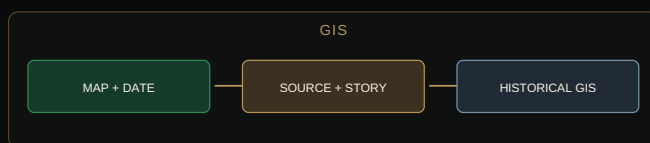
41. AI image restoration — preservation framework.



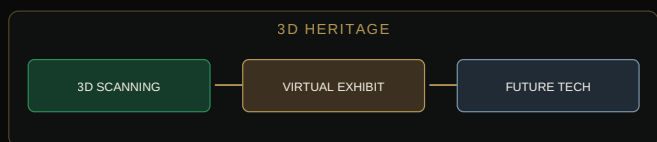
42. Deepfakes — preservation framework.



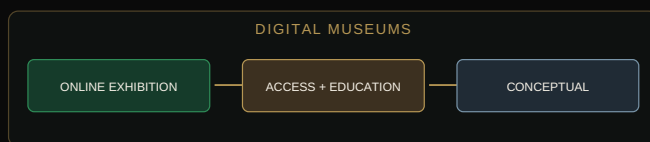
43. Digital humanities — preservation framework.



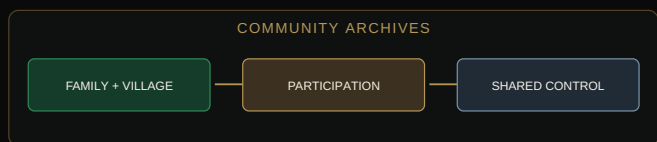
44. GIS — preservation framework.



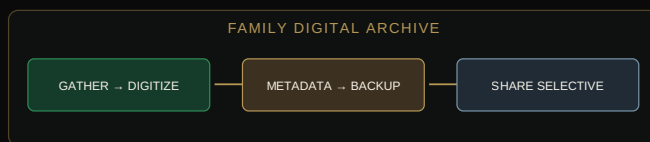
45. 3D heritage — preservation framework.



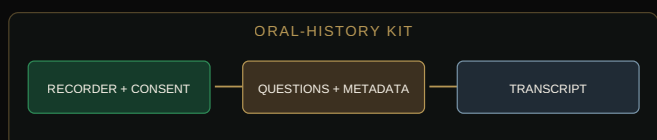
46. Digital museums — preservation framework.



47. Community archives — preservation framework.



48. Family digital archive — preservation framework.



49. Oral-history kit — preservation framework.



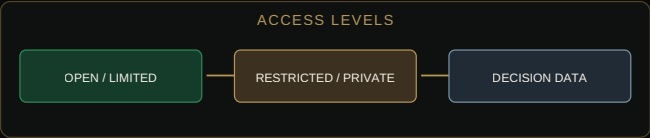
50. What to record — preservation framework.



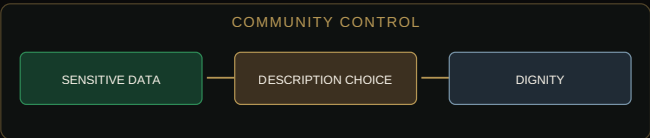
51. Privacy — preservation framework.



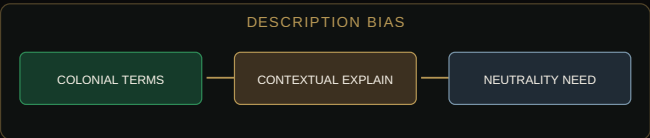
52. Children — preservation framework.



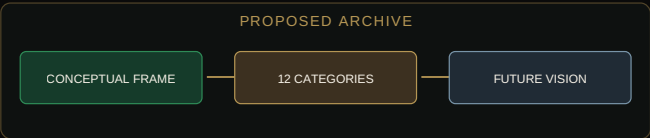
53. Intellectual property — preservation framework.



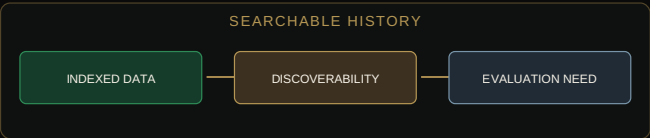
54. Access levels — preservation framework.



55. Community control — preservation framework.



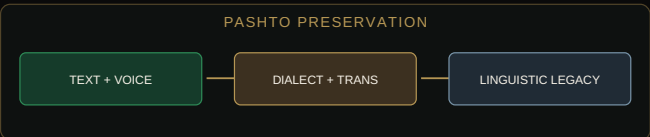
56. Description bias — preservation framework.



57. Proposed archive — preservation framework.



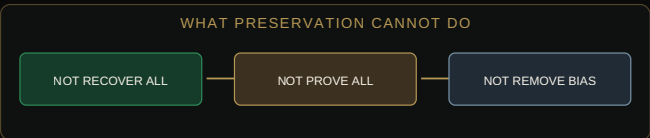
58. Searchable history — preservation framework.



59. Education — preservation framework.

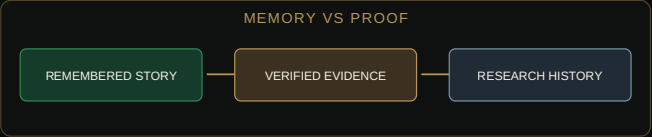


60. Pashto preservation — preservation framework.



61. Future generations — preservation framework.

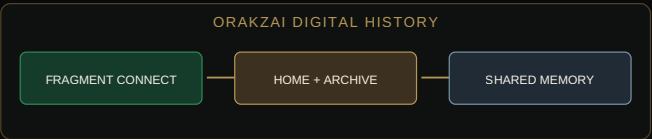
62. What preservation cannot do — preservation framework.



63. Memory vs proof — preservation framework.



64. Future archive — preservation framework.



65. Orakzai digital history — preservation framework.



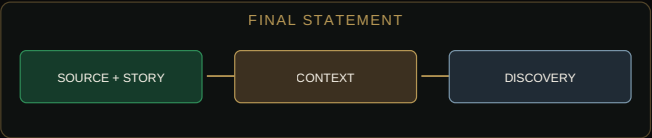
66. Research gap — preservation framework.



67. Oral-history questions — preservation framework.



68. Author reflection — preservation framework.



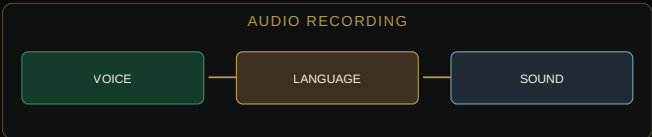
69. Final statement — preservation framework.



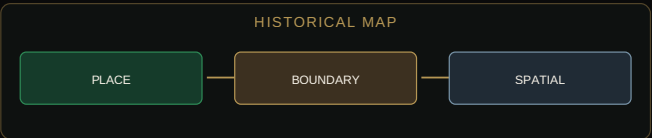
70. Family photograph — preservation framework.



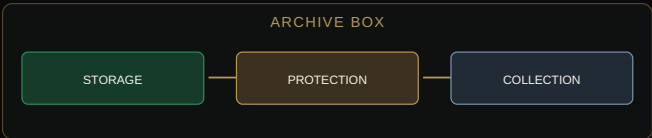
71. Manuscript — preservation framework.



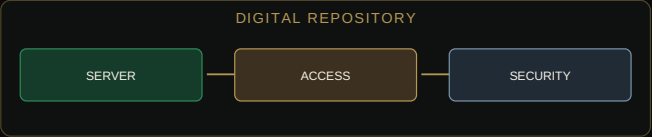
72. Audio recording — preservation framework.



74. Archive box — preservation framework.

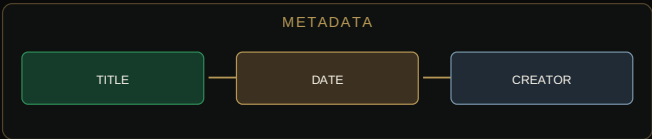
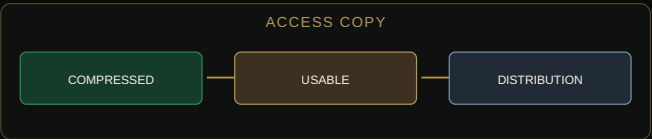


73. Historical map — preservation framework.



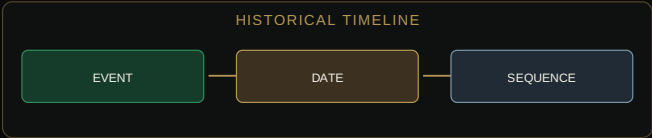
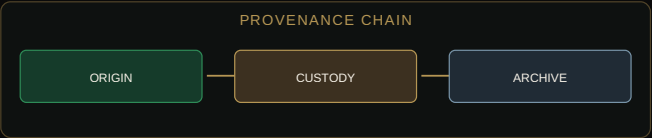
75. Digital repository — preservation framework.

76. Preservation master — preservation framework.



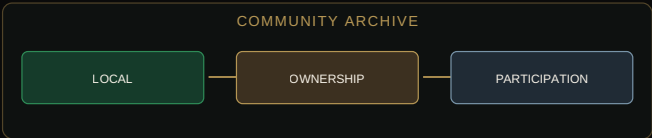
77. Access copy — preservation framework.

78. Metadata — preservation framework.



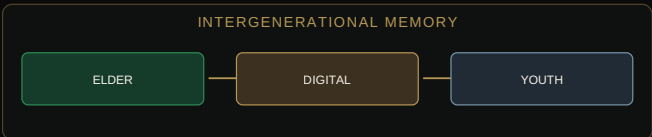
79. Provenance chain — preservation framework.

80. Historical timeline — preservation framework.



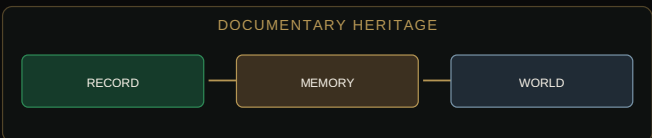
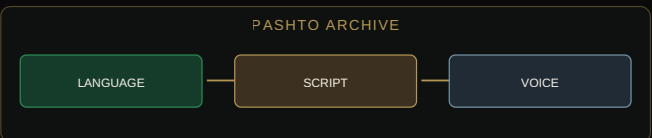
81. Digital integrity — preservation framework.

82. Community archive — preservation framework.



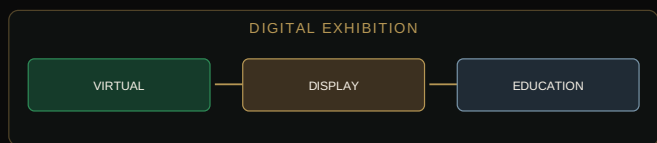
83. Future researcher — preservation framework.

84. Intergenerational memory — preservation framework.

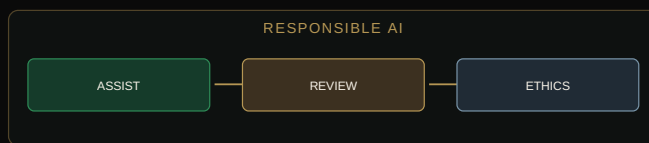


85. Pashto archive — preservation framework.

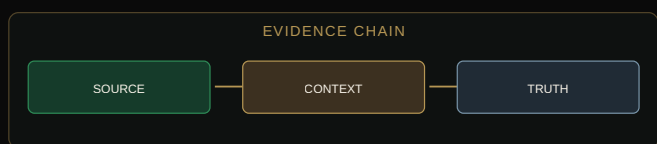
86. Documentary heritage — preservation framework.



87. Digital exhibition — preservation framework.



88. Responsible AI — preservation framework.



89. Evidence chain — preservation framework.



90. Digital bridge — preservation framework.

RESEARCH GAP: WHAT STILL NEEDS TO BE DOCUMENTED

- Family photograph collections
- Village histories
- Oral histories (Elders)
- Pashto dialect recordings
- Historical maps
- Manuscripts
- Land records (where accessible)
- Migration records
- Community newspapers
- Sports and festival records
- Music and poetry recordings
- Women's oral histories
- Children's memories
- Diaspora archives
- Colonial and post-1947 records
- Historical buildings
- Traditional crafts
- Agricultural knowledge
- Place-name histories
- Community preservation standards

“An archive becomes meaningful when evidence survives with enough context for another generation to understand what it is, where it came from, and why it matters.”

ORAL HISTORY QUESTIONS

1. What is the oldest photograph in your family?
2. Who is in it? When and where was it taken?
3. What story does your family associate with it?
4. Which family documents should be preserved?
5. Which stories did your grandparents tell?
6. Which village places have changed?
7. Which Pashto words are disappearing?

8. Which historical objects does your family still have?
9. Which memories should be recorded privately?
10. What should children know about their family history?
11. Which records were lost through migration or conflict?
12. What historical material exists outside formal archives?
13. What should an Orakzai digital archive contain?
14. Who should control access to sensitive records?
15. What should future generations be able to find?

AUTHOR'S REFLECTION

“Every generation inherits more than stories. It inherits photographs, names, documents, voices, places, objects, and memories. Some survive by accident; others disappear quietly. I believe technology gives us an opportunity to be more deliberate.

We can record the voice of an elder before it is lost. We can preserve a photograph before it fades. We can digitize a document before its pages become unreadable. We can connect a family memory with a historical source.

But preservation also requires humility. Not everything we remember is automatically proven. Not every photograph tells us everything we think it does. Not every digital reconstruction is history. The responsibility is therefore not simply to save more files. It is to save evidence with context. If we preserve the original, document its source, protect its integrity and explain what we know and what we do not know, then digital technology can become more than a storage system. It can become a bridge between generations. A bridge from memory to evidence. And from evidence to understanding.”

**PRESERVE THE SOURCE. PRESERVE THE STORY.
PRESERVE THE CONTEXT.
SO THE NEXT GENERATION CAN DISCOVER
THE HISTORY FOR ITSELF.**

RESEARCH SOURCES & FOOTNOTES

1. UNESCO, *UNESCO/PERSIST Guidelines for the Selection of Digital Heritage for Long-Term Preservation*, 2021.

2. Citizens Archive of Pakistan, "Preserving History: The Citizens Archive of Pakistan," *Oral History Society*, 2023.
3. Digital Preservation Coalition, *Digital Preservation Handbook*, 2025.
4. IFLA, *Dublin Core Metadata Initiative Standards*, 2021.
5. Boyd, D., "Oral History in the Digital Age," *OHDA*, 2012.